SITE-SETUP SKILL

Your simple guide

Start any website project the right way, one small step at a time.

This guide is interactive. Click the stage buttons to jump around. Tick the boxes as you go (they work in most PDF viewers). Select the grey boxes to copy what to type.

What it is, in 30 seconds

1. It sets up with you
Helps you make your project folder and starter files, explaining each one. It even walks you through your private .env file.

2. It asks
Simple questions about your business, a few at a time. Your facts and your voice get written down.

3. It hands you a prompt
A ready-to-paste build prompt, made from your own answers.

NOTE It does **not** build the website itself, and it **never makes up facts** about your business. At every step it explains what it is doing and **waits for you to say "go"**.

TIP Brand new to folders and files? Just say **"I'm brand new"** at the start. Claude explains every word, makes the folder and files **with you, before it asks anything else**, and shows you where your .env file is and how to fill it in. Jump to the beginner help →

The journey (click a stage)

0 Check	**1** Folder first	**2** Questions
3 Project files	**4** Safety check	**5** Your uploads
6 Upload check	**7** Design and plan	**8** Build prompt

Stages 0 to 6 set up and check your project, starting with your folder. Stage 7 agrees the look and the plan. Stage 8 writes your build prompt.

Before you start

Tick each box when it is true for you. The grey ones are optional and can wait.

- [ ] **Node.js is installed** (version 20 or higher). To check, type `node -v` in a terminal.
- [ ] **A folder for this project** with Claude Code opened inside it. No folder yet? Claude helps you make one (see page 4).
- [ ] **The skill is in that folder:** `.claude/skills/site-setup` (or in your personal skills folder).
- [ ] Optional: free **GitHub** and **Render** accounts. You can create them later.
- [ ] Optional: an **Unsplash Access Key**, only if you want free stock photos.
- [ ] Optional: **your own photos** (everyone in them agreed), your **logo**, a **keyword list**.

The minimum you must tell it

1. Business name
2. What you do, in one sentence
3. What you offer, or the pages you need
4. How people should contact you
5. The main goal of the site
6. The framework (or accept its recommendation)
7. How your writing should sound
8. A look you like (or pick one it suggests)

Everything else can be "I don't know". It leaves a note for later and moves on. Missing items become hidden sections or simple placeholders. It will not guess.

NEVER paste a key or password into the chat. **Type it into the** `.env` **file yourself.** If you ever paste one by mistake, create a new key and replace it.

The nine stages

Each row: what Claude does, what you do, and a box to tick. After most stages, **say "go"** to continue.

Tick	Stage	What Claude does	What you do
☐	**0 Check**	Looks at your computer and folder (Node, git, skills). If a project already exists, it only checks and changes nothing.	Read the short report. Fix anything it flags.
☐	**1 Folder first**	Checks you are in the right folder (and helps you make one if not). Creates the starter folders and files, explains each one, and offers to open the folder so you can see it. Offers to walk you through `.env` now.	Say how comfortable you are. Make or open a folder if asked. Look at what it made. Say "go".
☐	**2 Questions**	Asks about your business, one small group at a time, and reads your answers back.	Answer in plain words. "I don't know" is fine.
☐	**3 Project files**	Writes your project rulebook (`CLAUDE.md`) and your voice and facts files, only from your answers. Then adds the folders and keys your website type needs.	Read them. Correct anything wrong.
☐	**4 Safety check**	Runs a checking script and shows proof that private files cannot be uploaded by mistake.	Look for FAIL lines. Ask it to fix and re-run.
☐	**5 Your uploads**	**Stops** and gives you a checklist. Walks you through `.env` if you have not done it yet.	Add photos, logos and your keyword list. Type keys into `.env` yourself. Then say "go".
☐	**6 Upload check**	Lists your files and flags risky ones (receipts, IDs, screenshots). Changes nothing.	Remove anything flagged. Say "go".
☐	**7 Design and plan**	Suggests two or three simple looks if you have no reference, then a build plan.	Pick a look. Approve or change the plan.
☐	**8 Build prompt**	Writes `docs/BUILD-PROMPT.md` and shows it in the chat.	Copy it. Open a **new chat** in the same folder and paste it.

↑ Back to the map

First time? Your folder and your .env file

Say **"brand new"** at the start and Claude explains every word and does the file steps with you. Ask for this help any time: type `site-setup env`.

1. Your project folder

- [ ] **Pick a good place:** inside **Documents**, with a short lowercase name and no spaces, for example `my-business-site`.
- [ ] **Avoid** your home folder, Desktop, Downloads, and folders synced by OneDrive, iCloud or Dropbox.
- [ ] **Make it.** Mac: Finder, Documents, File menu, New Folder. Windows: File Explorer, Documents, right-click, New, Folder.
- [ ] **Open Claude Code inside it** and start a **new chat** there (a running chat cannot move folders).
- [ ] **Type** `site-setup`. Claude creates the starter folders and says what each one is for.

2. See the hidden files

Names that start with a dot, like `.env`, are hidden on purpose. To show them:

Mac	Windows	Linux
Press **`Command + Shift + .`**	File Explorer, **View**, **Show**, **Hidden items**	Press **`Ctrl + H`**

3. Put your key in .env

- [ ] **Get your key.** Go to unsplash.com/developers, Your apps, New Application, then copy the **Access Key** (never the Secret Key).
- [ ] **Find the file.** `.env` is in your project folder, next to `CLAUDE.md`. Say yes if Claude offers to open the folder for you.
- [ ] **Open it.** Mac: right-click, Open With, TextEdit (then Format, Make Plain Text). Windows: right-click, Open with, Notepad.
- [ ] **Paste the key right after the equals sign**, with no spaces and no quotes: `UNSPLASH_ACCESS_KEY=your-key-here`
- [ ] **Save** (Command + S or Ctrl + S) and close.
- [ ] **Check it.** Say `check my .env`. Claude shows **SET** or **empty** for each key, and never the key itself.

> **NEVER** paste your key into the chat. Claude never needs to see it, and never prints the file.

Windows tip: if the file became `.env.txt`, turn on **View, Show, File name extensions** and rename it to exactly `.env`.

What to type

Select a grey box to copy it. Type it in a **new chat** inside your project folder.

Starting

```
site-setup
```

Start a new project from scratch.

```
site-setup audit
```

Check an existing project. It changes nothing.

```
site-setup docs/my-build-spec.pdf
```

Start from your own build spec. Use your file's name.

```
site-setup build-prompt
```

Jump to the design and plan, then write the build prompt, on an existing project.

If you are new

```
I'm brand new. Please guide me step by step.
```

Say this at the start. Claude explains every word and does the file steps with you.

```
site-setup env
```

Any time: walk me through finding and filling my .env file.

Moving on

```
go
```

Say this at each stop to continue. Read the report first.

After the build prompt

- [ ] Open a **new chat** in the same project folder.
- [ ] **Paste** the build prompt from `docs/BUILD-PROMPT.md` and answer its questions.
- [ ] **Approve the image map** before any photo is placed. Check every report before saying go.
- [ ] When the site is built and you are happy, you can add posts with the `blog` skill.

Choosing images each time you write a post:

`blog images=unsplash` free stock photos	**`blog images=local`** your own photos folder	**`blog images=mixed`** yours first, stock to fill gaps	**`blog images=none`** marked placeholders

↑ Back to the map

Get the best results

- [ ] **Give real facts, not guesses.** A blank is better than a wrong number.
- [ ] **Share a few things you have written** (emails, posts) so the writing sounds like you.
- [ ] **Bring a design reference** if you can: a screenshot or a link of a site whose look you like.
- [ ] **Use your own photos** for anything about your own work, people and results.
- [ ] **Read each report before you say go.** That is how mistakes get caught early.

If something looks wrong

It says Node is too old or missing	Install the current LTS version from nodejs.org, then start again.
The safety check shows FAIL	Read the line. It says what is wrong. Ask Claude to fix it and run the check again.
A file already exists	The skill never overwrites. It saves the new version next to it, ending in `.new`.
The skill does not appear	Check the file `.claude/skills/site-setup/SKILL.md` exists in your project, then start a **new chat**.
I pasted a key into the chat	Make a new key in that service and replace it in `.env`. Treat the old one as lost.

All done? Tick it off

- [ ] Project files created and read.
- [ ] Safety check passed with no FAIL lines.
- [ ] Uploads added and checked.
- [ ] Design and plan approved.
- [ ] Build prompt saved and pasted into a new chat.

My notes (click the box and type):

↑ Back to the map